

and create misperceptions about your company in the market, which, in turn, could turn prospective customers, employees and investors away from your organisation.

Chances are that you may not even be conscious about it, but one thing is certain: Your brand is all your customers know about you. It's neither the products you sell, nor the services you offer. It is something much greater; even greater than the sum total of both. Your brand doesn't even exist in material form. And yet, it is your brand which singularly determines the future of your business.

Let your brand do the selling

Turn off the television. Avoid your radio. Shun the morning paper. Why, you may ask? The thunderous gloom and doom predictions would lead you to believe that you should stop spending and stuff your hard-earned cash under your mattress. Though whether we actually enter a recession or not is still up for debate, it does bring up a prickly subject for many businesses. Should you continue investing in marketing or defer those expenditures until the economy picks up?

A simple and effective way for businesses to gain over their competitors during a slowdown is to remain focused on their market presence. A downturn is the time of less 'noise' and congestion (fewer advertisers) in the marketplace and hence is the best time to increase consumer awareness at a relatively low cost. This was confirmed by more than three-fourth of the EFY respondents (77 per cent).

If your brand is managed well, connects with your target on an emotional level, clearly demonstrates value to your audience and instills loyalty, you are likely to fare well irrespective of the economic condition. Your customer base may be niche one but you have to establish connectivity between your brand and the masses. Not the cost but the uniqueness of the approach is the key to success.

Tulip Telecom's recent hoarding campaign with "Jai Ho" slogan is one example. It features the caricature of famous music director A.R. Rahman holding the Oscar trophy with the slogan "Tulip making it possible." According to Tulip Connect, outdoor hoardings are displayed in public places and viewed by the masses. It doesn't make sense to have a communication which only caters to the company's niche segment, which won't be more than 0.25 per cent of the audience viewing it.

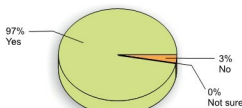
Representations like these are quite successful in generating the curiosity and hence the buzz. Viewers tend to think how Tulip is related with the Oscar story of Rahman. Once they start thinking, they get aware of the brand. It may also drive some enthusiastic viewers to the Tulip website as the Web address is also given in the hoarding. Surprisingly, a hoarding campaign with caricature is much cheaper than portraying the actual face of the celebrity. Isn't it an effective approach for brand promotion?

Brand matters

Ninety-one per cent of the survey respondents believed that businesses which continue to invest resources to market their brand during hard economic times perform better not only during a slowdown but also when the economy picks up. This strategy helps bolster consumers' confidence, making them feel that they have chosen the right product from the right firm. In contrast, businesses which fail to recognise the need for brand management during a slump and take injudicious cost-cutting measures are most likely to under-perform both during and

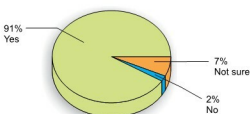
BRANDS GAIN VALUE

Importance of branding



BRANDING KEEPS THE BUSINESS AFLOAT

Importance of brand management in defying recession



after the dark economic phase.

It is also worthwhile noting that the importance of a brand is not only in sustainable marketing of the firm's products or services to the end consumer. The brand value of the organisation also helps to attract and retain high-quality people. In this context, apart from brand image, parameters like compensation and benefits, employee satisfaction and work culture go a long way in building and sustaining the brand value.

Blending tradition with innovation

Building an integrated marketing plan that employs the right vehicles across multiple channels to communicate your message is imperative to support your efforts in creating a strong brand. There are many aspects to consider: Who is your audience? What channels can you use to reach them better? What expectations do they have about how you communicate with them? How can you engage with them most effectively? What message will you deliver? What must you do internally or opera-